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Environmental Working Group: PFAS Tap Water Protections for Almost 19 Million Californians at Risk If EPA Weakens Limits

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WASHINGTON, May 8 -- The Environmental Working Group issued the following news release:

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PFAS tap water protections for almost 19 million Californians at risk if EPA weakens limits

Administrator Lee Zeldin will decide fate of landmark 'forever chemicals' drinking water standards

SACRAMENTO, Calif. -- Nearly 19 million Californians could lose critical protections against the toxic "forever chemicals" known as PFAS in their tap water if the Environmental Protection Agency rolls back its science-based PFAS drinking water standards, according to a new Environmental Working Group analysis.

The EPA's landmark national standards for six PFAS in drinking water, finalized in 2024, set limits of just 4 parts per trillion for PFOA and PFOS - two of the most well-studied and notorious PFAS. But these safeguards are now under threat as polluters and industry groups seek to dismantle them.

"Rolling back these vital protections would put the health of millions of Californians at serious risk," said Bernadette Del Chiaro, EWG's California senior vice president. "If the EPA succumbs to polluter pressure, families across California - from San Diego to Fresno -- will be stuck drinking water laced with toxic PFAS.

"I hope Administrator Zeldin holds firm in his commitment to protect public health from PFAS but, out here in California, our right to safe drinking water should not be subject to the topsy-turvy politics of Washington. California must act with certainty and speed when it comes to protecting the public from PFAS in drinking water," said Del Chiaro.

EWG's new analysis reveals that 177 California water systems serving over 18.9 million people - roughly half the state's population - have detected PFAS above the EPA's health-protective limits between 2023 and 2025. This includes detections for the forever chemicals PFOA, PFOS, PFHxS and PFNA, all covered by the federal standards.

If the EPA rolls back those standards, major urban centers such as Los Angeles, San Diego, Orange County and Fresno would no longer be required to remove toxic PFAS from drinking water systems. This would leave millions of residents vulnerable to these dangerous chemicals in their tap water.

Other communities, including Sacramento, Riverside, Glendale, Oceanside, Atwater and Adelanto, could fall through the cracks entirely if weaker state thresholds remain in place.

"Simply put, California has a PFAS problem. We need swift state action so Californians can trust their health is being protected when they fill a glass with water from the tap," Del Chiaro said.

State action urgently needed to fill the gap

California currently has only non-binding "response levels" for a few types of PFAS -- limits that are far weaker than the EPA's enforceable standards. In many cases, water utilities are not required to reduce PFAS levels, even when they exceed health guidelines.

"California should not leave itself vulnerable to the actions of Washington," said Jared Hayes, a senior policy analyst at EWG and co-author of the new analysis. "We need enforceable state-level protections now to ensure that Californians are protected if federal protections fail."

California Assembly Bill 794, introduced by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) , would establish state-level regulations to ensure that Californians aren't drinking PFAS-tainted tap water long into the future, even if federal standards are weakened.

The bill would direct the State Water Resources Control Board to adopt emergency PFAS regulations and begin setting enforceable state standards that are at least as strong as federal limits.

California's widespread PFAS threat at communities and military bases

PFAS contamination is pervasive in California, with 49 current and former military sites reporting groundwater or drinking water contamination. San Diego County's Camp Pendleton, whose drinking water serves more than 56,000 people, continues to report dangerous levels of PFAS in its water systems, due in part to legacy contamination.

If the EPA rolls back federal PFAS cleanup requirements, military bases and surrounding communities could be left at even greater risk of exposure.

"PFAS contamination at military bases like Camp Pendleton is not just a hypothetical threat -- it's a growing crisis that demands immediate action," said Hayes. "Without federal standards, the Defense Department can delay cleanup, leaving California's military families and communities exposed to hazardous chemicals."

Health harms

PFAS are likely present in groundwater and nearby private wells, in addition to public water systems. More than 5,200 industrial facilities in the state may be releasing PFAS into the environment.

PFAS are a class of thousands of chemicals known as "forever chemicals" because they persist in both the environment and the human body, never breaking down and accumulating over time.

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention has detected PFAS in the blood of 99 percent of Americans, including newborn babies.

For decades, polluters hid the health harms of PFAS from regulators, workers and neighboring communities. PFAS have been linked to cancer, reproductive harm, immune system damage and other serious health problems, even at low levels.

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The Environmental Working Group is a nonprofit, non-partisan organization that empowers people to live healthier lives in a healthier environment. Through research, advocacy and unique education tools, EWG drives consumer choice and civic action.

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Original text here: https://www.ewg.org/news-insights/news-release/2025/05/pfas-tap-water-protections-almost-19-million-californians-risk

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